



If you have decided to **try to get pregnant**, you may be excited but unsure of what to do next. There are ways to **maximize your fertility** and prepare for pregnancy, but once you've done those things, relax and **let nature take its course**. If you don't conceive quickly, try not to get disheartened. It is normal for it to take some time.

Trying to conceive

Preparing for pregnancy

Once you've decided to get pregnant, there are some practical steps you need to take—from stopping any birth control and making lifestyle changes to checking your immunity to certain infections. Taking these actions before you conceive will put you in the best possible health for pregnancy.

During pregnancy, the focus is understandably on the woman. However, at this preconception stage it really is about both of you. Men, as well as women, can do much to improve their fertility by making dietary and lifestyle changes, with the added advantage that when the baby arrives he will have two fit and healthy parents.

You can maximize your chances of becoming pregnant by tracking your menstrual cycle and knowing the optimal time to conceive. In addition to using an ovulation prediction kit, you can learn to spot the natural signs that you are ovulating. Be aware, though, of the importance of relaxing and enjoying the process of getting pregnant. Becoming too focused on conceiving and feeling stressed can spoil your enjoyment of this special and exciting time, and actually adversely affect your fertility. It can also negatively affect your relationship if your lovemaking is all about getting pregnant.

Couples who have been trying to get pregnant for some time may want to investigate why they have had no success so far. This is especially true of older couples, who may want to seek advice sooner rather than later. There is a great deal of help available, starting with basic fertility tests, such as blood tests and ultrasounds, to rule out any physical problems. Sometimes knowing that your reproductive organs are in good health can help you relax and actually improve your chances of conceiving.

For couples who are considering having fertility treatment, this chapter outlines the options available, such as in vitro fertilization (IVF). There is a wide range of fertility treatments available and success rates are improving gradually all the time.

Getting pregnant again

If you are trying to have another baby, the preparation is the same. Although it is harder to prioritize yourself once you are a mother, being in good shape will benefit your conception chances and provide the energy to care for more children. If you had any problems conceiving or during previous pregnancies, discuss these with your doctor so you can go into this pregnancy feeling happy and confident.